



SpaceX needs landing pads

SpaceX, which is preparing for commercial Falcon heavy vehicle needs more landing pads
digit.in/SpaceXLandingpads



Resurrecting Mars data

Nasa scientists are trying to resurrect Vikings 1's analogue Mars data after 40 years. digit.in/viking1Data

SPACE SUPERSTITIONS

A guide to curious cosmic traditions

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Introduction and a Sphex-iation

This story, spanning the farthest of human reaches, begins with a winsome wasp, the Sphex. Though it flies around quite haphazardly, the Sphex lives a very routine life. It digs a hole, lays its larvae, and then heads out to hunt. It paralyzes its prey, drags it to the entrance of the hole, and enters to check that all is well, before taking dinner all the way home. Here's the fun part - The wasp's behaviour only ever occurs in that sequence. If you displace the prey while

the Sphex is scouting its den, the wasp will return the body to the entrance and go in to scout again. In fact it will repeat the exact same thing again and again, as many times as you, the experimenter, care to displace its children's future food.

Clearly, biological programming exists. Yet while a wasp may not have the conscious ability to override its genetically predetermined behaviour, we mighty-minded humans certainly do.. Or do we? What does our consciousness do when it encounters the inexplicable? Seeing as, even rocket scientists are superstitious (which happens to be the meat of this

article), are we genetically predisposed to such unfounded behaviour? The thought of space agencies sticking to superstitions makes it seem like they are run by the aunties next door, who incessantly suggest which stones are suitable for which character flaw or flavour of success. It's no secret that we humans are an irrational lot, but to think that it pervades the institutions dedicated to rational thinking of the highest order! Baffling!

The very reason for the existence of Science is our need to predict the future and control the outcome to the best of our ability. Of course, in the process we also